Week 28

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 7 · LESSON 4

Hell

BIG IDEA

Hell is the tragic consequence of rejecting God: life with all of God's goodness taken away. God doesn't force anyone into relationship with him, so he honors our choice, and your job this week is to let students wrestle with that hard truth patiently.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. The book Love Wins by Rob Bell stirred controversy; students were drawn to its idea of endless second chances and that hell isn't really accurate.
2. Jesus is clear that hell exists, but it's easy to discount because none of us wants to face consequences. Hell is not God: it's what rejecting him leads to.
3. Intro experience: students describe their favorite place, then strip away every good thing about it, to sense what hell might be like.
4. Common grace is God sustaining every breath, the sun and the rain for everyone. Picture all of that removed: uninhabitable.
5. God doesn't send people to hell; we send ourselves by not wanting him. God invites, never forces: that is love in action.
6. Invite open discussion rather than just pointing to the Bible. With four lessons left, take stock of where each student is now and don't rush them.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. How comfortable am I letting a student say they aren't sure about hell without shutting them down?
2. Where do I see God's common grace in my own ordinary day?
3. Looking back at my notes from the start of the year, where is each student now?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. Describe your favorite place. What would it be like with every good thing about it removed?
2. What everyday good things do you think God provides for everyone, whether they choose him or not?
3. Why do you think so many people would rather believe hell isn't real?
4. How can a good and loving God allow hell? What makes that hard, and what helps?
5. What does it mean that God invites us into relationship but never forces us?

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The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

A book that stirred controversy

0:06 Several years ago I was teaching one of my Bible classes when a really important and significant book in the lives of most evangelical Christians came out. It created a firestorm of conversation, waves of controversy, and all kinds of things happening in the Christian world. The book was Love Wins by Rob Bell, and I had all kinds of parents asking me if we were going to read it, or demanding that we don't read it. I had students asking me about it, so I finally said enough is enough — I need to figure out what the story is. So I read it, and I used it as a discussion point for my students.

0:48 The book had an incredible way of bringing up some really, really important topics to discuss. But what was interesting was that the students seemed to really gravitate toward what the book was suggesting: that we somehow have this endless chance-after-chance cycle of getting to God; that if we miss it the first time, we'll get a second try at it; and that the idea of hell is really not all that accurate. It's an interesting conversation piece, and something that we ought to talk about.

The Bible is clear

1:26 But the Bible is pretty clear. We've talked about the reliability of this text, and Jesus is really clear that hell exists. Yet it's so easy for our students to want to discount that, because we don't necessarily want to be held accountable for our actions, and we don't really want to face the consequences. Who wants to face consequences? So the question I'm often asked is, okay, well, what is hell like? I don't know. It's probably not nice. I don't really know. I don't know if I want to know. It's not God. Hell is the tragic consequence of rejecting God.

Imagining what hell is like

2:02 To help your students understand what this tragic consequence would be like, the intro experience takes them through a mini journey of imagining the best possible place — their favorite place. Why do you love it? Describe it. Even put pictures in there. And then remove all of its goodness, everything. Cross out any word that has good meaning. Remove all benefits from that place, all value, all joy, all refreshing qualities, all of it. What would that place be like then? That should help them get into that space of what hell would be like.

2:50 I often describe it to students this way. Common grace is the grace that God provides all of us, right? The fact that God is sustaining this world, every breath that I take, the sun that is shining, the air that is blowing, the trees growing, all the rain that falls, all of the things that happen on the righteous and the unrighteous — those are all common grace, because God is here, active and moving in history, and participating in sovereignly taking care of this world.

3:27 Now remove all of that. God is not doing any of that. Can you imagine what it might be like to not be able to take a breath, to not have the sun shining, to not have this earth sustained by Him? Uninhabitable. That's the way I try to paint a picture of hell for students, to give them that sense of, oh, God is doing all of this for me whether I choose Him or not, right?

Does God send people to hell?

3:58 So then the question comes: well, wait a minute, how come God sends good people to hell? How come God sends anybody to hell? The short answer is that God doesn't send anybody — we send ourselves, because we choose to not want Him. I've often said that God honors our choices and allows us to choose not Him, and then gives us that very choice.

Small group time

4:26 So this week, small groups as always — but this week especially is super important, because all that we're talking about is going to come to a bit of a culmination. How can a God who we've already said is good be allowing evil and all those kinds of things, and how can He then have the existence of hell alongside that? If God is so good and so loving and He allows this kind of evil — and this is the question that has been posed to me several times — if God allows evil and allows the suffering to happen, and He's so good, then why would He have hell as a punishment for not believing? It almost seems like there's a contradiction. These are some of the questions that your students may bring up, or some version of them.

5:12 Again, open discussion. It's okay. If a student is not sure about hell, invite the discussion, invite the dialogue. Don't shoot them down and just point to Scripture and thump on the Bible like, well, this is what the Bible says. Well, yes — and we've talked about the reliability of the text and the authority of what's in there. But hell is a very, very real reality that can be difficult for some people to deal with. So be patient with your students as you bring them along if they're not quite there yet. Allow them the time to process it. And small groups are going to be one of those times where that happens.

5:50 And again, it's understanding that God wants us to choose Him. God wants us to be with Him. God invites us into relationship; He does not force us. And that is love in action: I want you to be with me. Imagine being married to somebody you love who doesn't love you back. That doesn't seem to make any sense.

Closing encouragement

6:14 Well, you made it through this week, and you've almost made it through the rest of the year. We continue to pray for you here, and we continue to pray for your students. I hope that this process of looking at hell and evil and suffering in a very, very real way has helped your students understand not only the point of suffering but the character of God a little bit better — and not only that this points to the existence of God in some sort of philosophical sense, but that even in the midst of suffering God is right there with us, feeling the pain along with us. I hope your students have a better picture of who God is and who Christ is, and what their salvation means, and all of that.

7:01 You have four more lessons to go. Now would be a good time to take another inventory of your students and where they are. Go back to some of your original notes about how your students started off this year and how they were around Unit 4. Where are they now? You've got some students who have made some decisions — I hope and pray that you have. Do you have some students who still have significant questions? If you need to, take some time and revisit some of those questions, either as a group, individually, or in small groups — wherever you need to. Don't rush this process. You've got four lessons to go, all of which are going to focus on wrapping things up and tying up some loose ends, and helping to send your students onward and forward into the world with greater conviction, greater confidence, and greater courage.